HCP 1044 (cpc_--___DE_Hier_fritzlehmann-16): a German number-cipher love card from Liese to Fritz Lehmann

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: deciphered in full (39 number groups, every number decoded); independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, no change to the decoded letters. Report dated 2026-11-03.

Origin and context

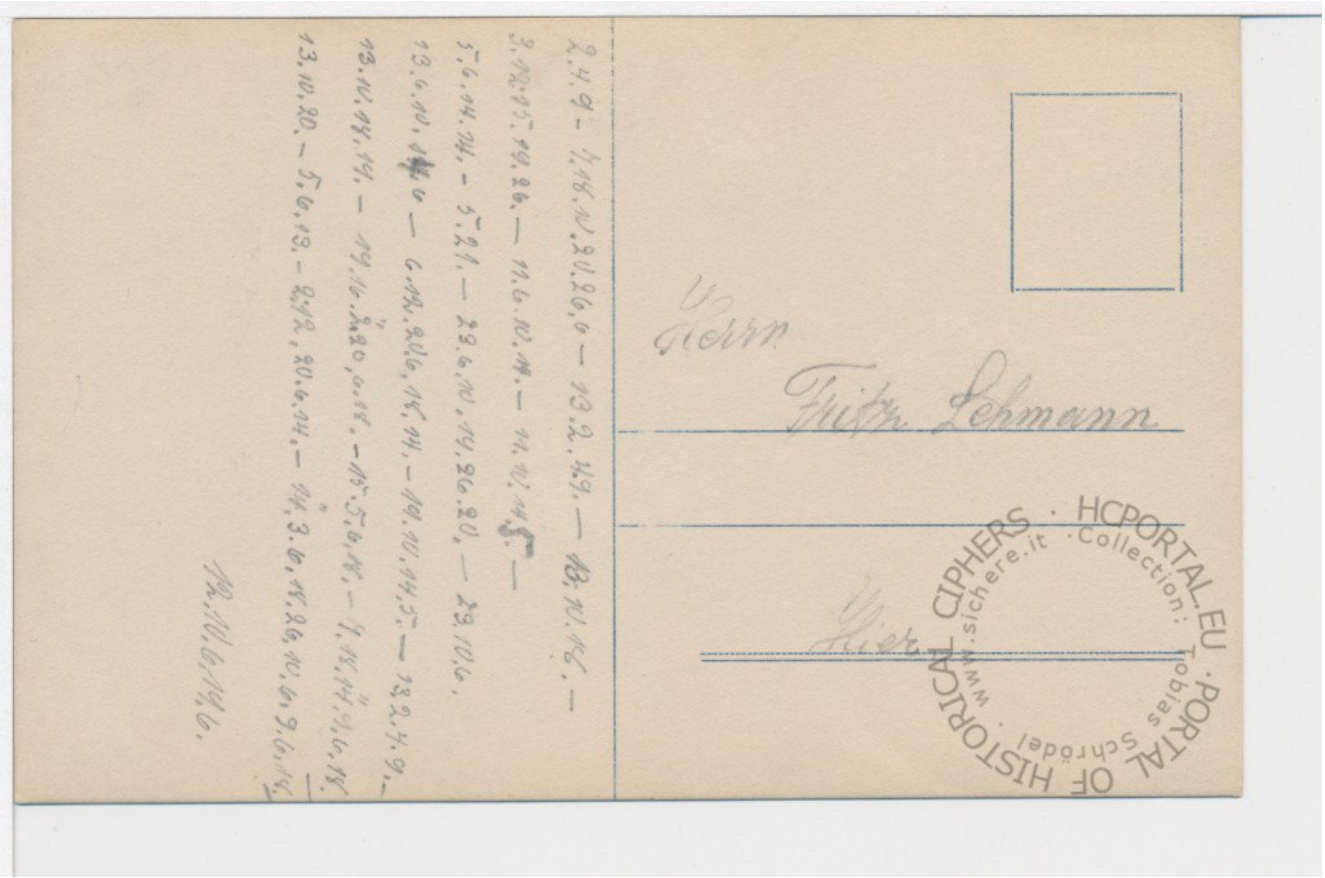
The cryptogram is record 1044 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1044), portal name cpc_--___DE_Hier_fritzlehmann-16, part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When it was captured on 2026-11-03 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard and T. Schrödel Collection, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Fritz Lehmann, with no transcription or solution attached. The portal links the HistoCrypt paper on the collection (https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166).

The picture side is a printed photographic love card: a kneeling man in evening dress holds the hand of a young woman, with the title "Lieb' mich, und die Welt ist mein!" ("Love me, and the world is mine!"), a short printed verse, and the publisher's mark KVG 2130/5. There is no handwriting on the picture side or along its edges.



Picture side (source/picture-large.jpg)

The address side reads in plain Kurrent script "Herrn Fritz Lehmann, Hier." ("Mr Fritz Lehmann, here", i.e. local delivery). The stamp box is printed but empty: there is no stamp and no postmark, so the card is undated and nothing can be hidden under a stamp. The message, six lines of pencil numbers and a signature, is written sideways on the left half of the address side.

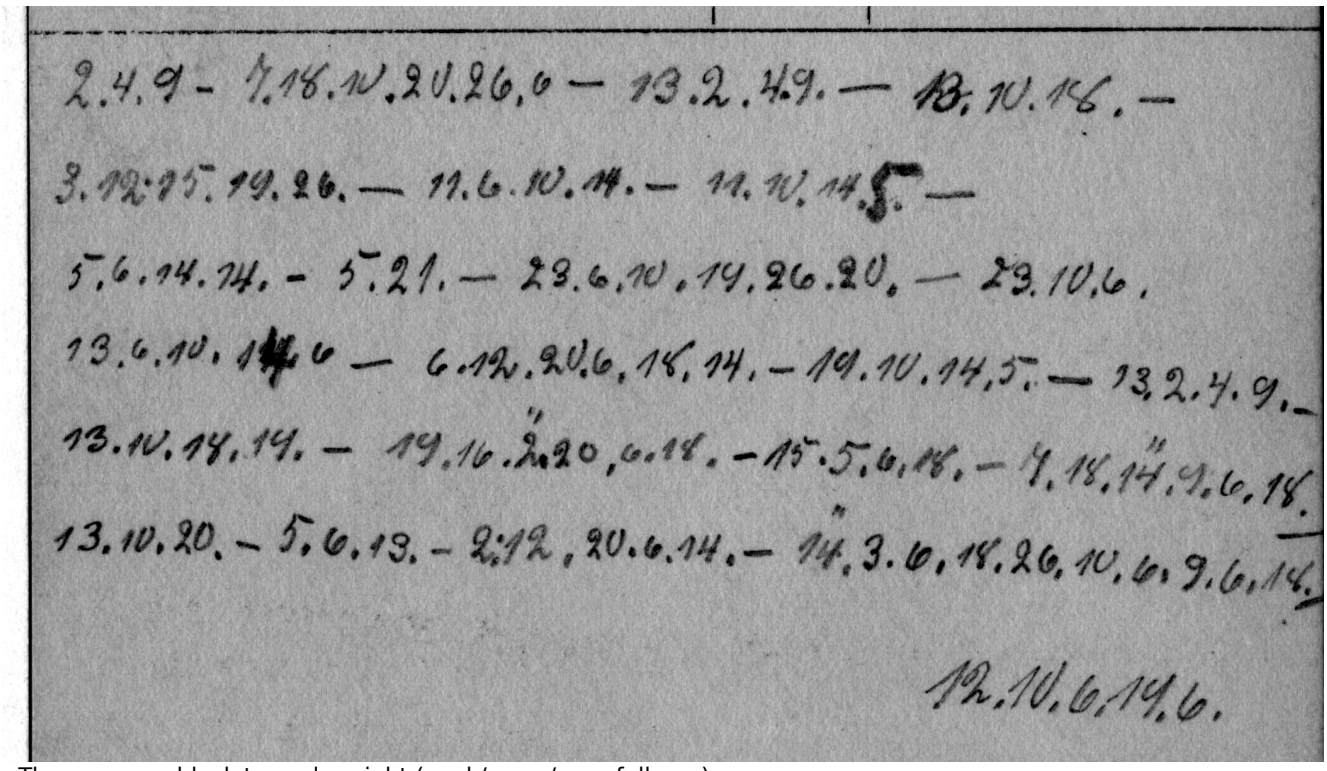


Address side (source/address-large.jpg)

The card belongs to a group of cipher cards to Fritz Lehmann in the Schrödel collection; the sister cards HCP 1051, 1113 and 1134 (in this repository) use the same number key and point to Schweidnitz / Freiburg in Silesia, around 1909.

Method

The transcription is manual and is the solver's own (Claude Opus 5.5, 2026-11-03), read from the un-converted high-resolution scan of the address side. The message block was cut out, turned upright and enlarged; doubtful numbers were enlarged further and compared with clear examples of the same digit elsewhere on the card. No OCR was used.



The message block turned upright (work/crops/msg_full.png)

The key was taken over from the Lehmann sister cards and tested on this card on its own evidence: it turns every number into a letter and every group into a German word, with nothing left over. The reviewer built its own table from the alphabet, decoded its own copy of the numbers, and read all 39 groups against its own enlargements; it agreed with the solver in every group.

One short web search (2026-11-03) found no published solution of this card.

Key

Number substitution (monoalphabetic), German. The 25-letter alphabet without J is numbered from 2:

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X	Y	Z
2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26

Dots separate numbers and dashes separate words. ß is written as SZ (19.26). Two dots over a number mark an umlaut (2 with dots = Ä). The short bar over each 5 is this writer's detached top stroke of the digit, not a separate sign.

Transcription

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2.4.9 - 7.18.10.20.26.6 - 13.2.4.9 - 13.10.18 -
3.12.15.19.26 - 11.6.10.14 - 11.10.14.5 -
5.6.14.14 - 5.21 - 23.6.10.19.26.20 - 23.10.6
13.6.10.14.6 - 6.12.20.6.18.14 - 19.10.14.5 - 13.2.4.9 -
13.10.18.19 - 19.16.2".20.6.18 - 15.5.6.18 - 7.18.14".9.6.18
13.10.20 - 5.6.13 - 2.12.20.6.14 - 14".3.6.18.26.10.6.9.6.14
12.10.6.19.6
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(" = two dots written over the number.)

Plaintext and translation

As decoded, line by line:

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ACH FRITZE MACH MIR
BLOSZ KEIN KIND
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DENN DU WEISZT WIE
MEINE ELTERN SIND MACH
MIRS SPA"TER ODER FRN"HER
MIT DEM ALTEN N"BERZIEHEN
LIESE
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German, normalised (punctuation and sentence division are editorial; the card has none):

"Ach Fritze, mach mir bloß kein Kind, denn du weißt, wie meine Eltern sind. Mach mir's später oder früher mit dem Alten überziehen. Liese."

An equally possible division of the end is "... Mach mir's später oder früher mit dem Alten. Überziehen!"

English: "Oh Fritz, just don't give me a baby, because you know what my parents are like. Do it for me sooner or later with the old one [the old thing?] pulled over. Liese." (alternative: "... with the old one. Pull it on!")

Slovak: "Ach Fritz, len mi nerob dieťa, veď vieš, akí sú moji rodičia. Urob mi to neskôr alebo skôr s tým starým natiahnutým. Liese." (alternatíva: "... s tým starým. Natiahnuť!")

"Fritze" is a colloquial north/east German form of Fritz. "Überziehen" (to pull over) and "Überzieher" were period slang for a condom, which fits the first sentence. The letters of the last two lines are certain; what exactly "später oder früher" and "mit dem Alten" mean is interpretation.

Uncertainties

1. Ü is written twice as N with two dots (14"): in FRÜHER and ÜBERZIEHEN. The digit under the dots is the same open, crossed 14 as in DENN, KEIN and ELTERN, clearly different from the 21 (U) of DU. It is read as the writer's own convention or slip (in Kurrent script n and u differ only by the u-bow) and normalised to Ü by word sense.
2. MIRS (line 5, first group, 13.10.18.19): at first sight the last two numbers looked like 14.14 ("MINN", no word); enlargement shows the lower loop of 18 and the closed upper loop with descender of 19.
3. Signature 12.10.6.19.6 = LIESE: the fourth number has the closed loop of 19; LIENE (14) is the weaker alternative.
4. MEINE: the fourth number is under a heavy blot (a correction). A "1" and a crossed 4-shape are visible, so 14 is supported by the strokes, but the call also rests partly on word sense.
5. MIR (line 1) has a retraced 13, and the final 5 of KIND is written very large; both readings are secure.
6. The card has no date, place or sender beyond the signature "Liese".

Review and what changed

An independent reviewer (a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent) ran the solver's decoder, decoded the numbers with its own script, read every group against its own enlargements, checked the picture side and the empty stamp box, and found no hidden or further writing. Verdict: **ACCEPT**, with four minor findings, all addressed:

1. The sister cards had been called "finished" while still in review; the wording was corrected (they are now closed).
2. The sentence division of the last two lines is editorial; the one-clause and two-sentence readings are now both given, and the unclear sense of "später oder früher" and "mit dem Alten" is stated.
3. The MEINE reading is now marked as resting partly on word sense.
4. A short web search for a published solution was run; none was found.

No decoded letter changed. The cipher type is a simple number substitution (MASC); the card has no steganographic part.